

Hanxiao Zhong

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PROFILE

PhD candidate in International Economics with strong analytical and quantitative skills, specializing in global trade, development, and policy analysis. Experienced in international and interdisciplinary collaboration, with a proven record in academic research, teaching, and student leadership.

EDUCATION

Katholieke Universiteit Leuven Leuven, Belgium	09/2023-Present
PhD in Economics	
• Supervisor: Prof. Hylke Vandenbussche (CEPR Research Fellow, CESifo Fellow)	
Geneva Graduate Institute Geneva, Switzerland	09/2021-09/2023
Master in International Economics	
• Key coursework: International Trade (with Prof. Richard Baldwin & Prof. Yuan Zi), Impact Evaluation, Economic Policy in Developing and Emerging Countries	
The Chinese University of Hong Kong, Shenzhen Shenzhen, China	09/2017-06/2021
Bachelor of Business Administration, Applied Economics	
• Key coursework: International Trade, Industrial Organization and Public Policy, China Economy, Financial Data Analysis	
Summer Programs	
National University of Singapore: Miracle and Crisis in East Asia	06/2019-07/2019
University of California, Berkeley: Business Analysis: Micro	06/2018-08/2018

HONORS & AWARDS

2025 Outstanding Student Association Cadre
SME Dean's List Award
2020 University Honors Excellent Student Leader Award
Bowen Scholarship

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

PhD Thesis: Digitalization and Firm Resilience to Shocks KU Leuven	10/2023-Present
1 st chapter (working paper): <i>Firm-level Digital Presence and Performance</i>	
• Developed a web-scraping program to collect data from 100,000+ websites and constructed a firm-level digital presence indicator.	
• Applied staggered Difference-in-differences framework and found digital presence has a causal impact of a 23.27% increase in sales.	
• Contributed to the literature on digitalization and firm behaviors.	
Research Assistant: Causal Relationship between FDI and Productivity KU Leuven	01/2024-10/2024
• Assisted in designing FDI exposure identification strategy.	
• Prepared firm-level dataset covering 9.3 million firms across 190+ countries using Orbis Global	
• Developed and optimized data analysis scripts using STATA, enhancing the efficiency by 40%.	
• Calculated the FDI elasticities of labor productivity in each GTAP sector for 15 geo-blocks.	
Master Thesis: The Impact of Environmental Governance on The Role of Water as A Source of Comparative Advantage Geneva	02/2023-06/2023
• Introduced environmental governance into water economic models; analyzed 216 sectors across 137 countries	
• Found superior environmental governance discourages water comparative advantage exploitation	
Case Study: The Fourth Sector Transition in Cambodia Geneva	03/2023
• Advised by Dr. Jennifer Blanke (former Chief Economist, World Economic Forum)	
• Proposed policy recommendations to the financial industry and the academia to facilitate the growth of social enterprises.	
Research Assistant: Guns and Finance Shenzhen	10/2019-10/2020
• Supervised by Prof. Bohui Zhang, Director of the Center for FinTech and Social Finance, Shenzhen Finance Institute	
• Participated in the project to gain experience in the frontline research in China's financial market.	
• Contributed data for 10,000 law enforcement agencies.	
• Proposed solutions to potential selection bias.	
Earlier Research Projects	07/2019-05/2020
• Individual project on determinants of China's cereal imports using gravity models and STATA.	
• East Asia studies projects on Japan-South Korea development strategies and Japan's lost decades.	

TEACHING & SUPERVISION

Teaching Assistant - European Economic Policy Seminars KU Leuven	02/2024-Present
Instructor: Prof. Hylke Vandenbussche	
• Prepared class materials including readings, guidebooks, slides, and data.	
• Taught causal inference methods (Difference-in-differences, Synthetic Control Method).	

- Graded student papers and presentations.

Daily Supervisor of Master's Students | KU Leuven

09/2023-09/2024

- Supervised two Master's students who independently conducted research on the same topic in Intra-BRICS trade.
- Supervised each student in literature review, methodological design, data analysis, and academic writing.
- Each project adopted a distinct methodological framework, resulting in differentiated analyses.
- Both theses were successfully defended in September 2024.

CONFERENCES

European Trade Study Group 2025 | Milan

09/2025

Presenter: Firm-level Digital Presence and Performance

Leuven-Louvain Trade Workshop | Leuven

11/2024

Presenter: Digital Presence and Firms' Performance

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Investment Fund Assistant | Guotai Junan Zhengyu Investment Co., Ltd.

06/2022-08/2022

- Analyzed the dynamics of China's PE market and regulatory impacts.
- Led case study on the investment potential embedded in Global Deposit Receipt (GDR). Specifically, the GDRs issued by Chinese firms and traded in London Stock Exchange, Swiss Exchange, and Frankfurt Stock Exchange.
- Other collaborative works:
 - Built a database of top 20 Chinese financial institutes' alternative investment strategies.
 - Estimated the potential returns in the privatizations of US-listed Chinese high-tech companies.
 - Evaluated the potentials in investing Pre-Real Estate Investment Trusts.

Investment Assistant Analyst | Shanghai Yize Investment Management Co., Ltd.

07/2021-08/2021

- Researched global iron ore market; visualized production plans of major firms (VALE, RIO, BHP, FMG)
- Completed an analytical report on the future development of China's iron industry in the context of carbon peaking and neutrality goals.

Investment Assistant | Guotai Junan Securities Co., Ltd.

05/2019-06/2019

- Screened over 100 Israeli high-tech companies for investment potential.
- Attended institutional negotiation between Guotai Junan and Cukierman & Co.

LEADERSHIP & VOLUNTEER EXPERIENCE

Director of External Relation | Chinese Students and Scholars Association of Leuven (CSAL)

08/2024-present

- Led external relations to enrich the campus life and career prospects of Chinese students in Leuven, securing strategic partnerships and corporate sponsorships.
- Spearheaded the on-the-ground organization of the *"Hainan Airline Cup" Sino-Belgian Youth Football Friendly*, commemorating the 53 years of friendship between the two nations.
 - Established partnership with Futi Club, a major Belgian youth football community, and recruited 8 of its members (7 players and 1 referee) for the event.
 - Hosted the event as the Master of Ceremonies (MC).
- Organized the **2025 CSAL Cup Badminton Tournament** with the sponsorship of Hainan Airlines and Huawei.
 - Secured in-kind sponsorships by presenting tailored promotional proposals to the corporate partners.
 - Facilitated the sponsorship lifecycle from negotiation to fulfillment.
 - Served as a head scorekeeper during the tournament.
- Facilitated the talent recruitment channel with **Zhangjiang Group**.
 - Coordinated the logistics for the corporate talk and built a long-term connection with the group's leadership and HR department for future student opportunities.

President | Open Economics

06/2022-09/2023

- Served the student community and linked resources to students who are interested in trade and development. Also exposed myself to the frontline of the research and practice in the multilateral trade today.
- Organized the high-end conference *Game Maker or Game Changer? 20 Years of China's Accession to WTO* with colleagues.
 - Presented *The Impacts of China's Accession to WTO on China and WTO* at the preparatory workshop of the conference.
 - Had deep conversation with Deputy Director-General ZHANG Xiangchen from WTO on how WTO is helping least developed countries to confront climate changes and the pandemic.
- Organized the panel discussion *Global Value Chain in Turbulent Times* with the help of Prof. Richard Baldwin from Geneva Graduate Institute.
 - Moderated the panel discussion and raised questions to Mr. Richard Bolwijn from UNCTAD, Dr. Ankai Xu from WTO, and Mr. Dmitry Grozoubinski from Geneva Trade Platform.
 - Gained insights about the current challenges to the GVC and the vision of service trade and green energy transition.

Vice President | Economics Club

05/2020-05/2021

- Organized an academic lecture—*A General Introduction on Statistical Software*.

- Launched and organized the writing of *Tips on Basic Microeconomics*.
- Established a platform for student-faculty communication.

SKILLS

- Computer: Microsoft Office, Wind, EViews, STATA, Python, and R
- Empirical strategies: Difference-in-Differences, IV, RDD, Matching, Time Series Analysis
- Language: Chinese (Native); English (Professional); French (Basic); Wu (Dialect)